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RePEc, a Tool and Open Dataset for and about Economists

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RePEc, a Tool and Open Dataset for and about Economists

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Abstract

RePEc is an initiative created by economists for economists in 1997. It functions primarily as a bibliographic tool, but it also collects various linked metadata about economists, their institutions, and their impact. Thus, a labor economist may be interested in RePEc beyond literature searches and tracking—namely, as a dataset describing a profession, its members, and their output.

This essay describes RePEc's origins and history, the many facets of its data and how the data can be accessed. It also provides some examples of scholarly studies leveraging RePEc data that could be of interest to labor economists and lead them to other uses of RePEc data.

JEL Classification: A11, A14, J44, J45

Keywords: RePEc, dataset, sociology of economics, economics profession

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1. RePEc, a short history

Publication delays are nothing new in economics. While there may be evidence that delays have gotten worse over time (Ellison 2002; Hadavand et al. 2021), they have always been the curse of academic economists. But, as economists would predict when a market suffers from major frictions, participants adapt to the circumstances. In this case, a culture of disseminating preprints, under the name of working papers or discussion papers, emerged among top institutions to speed up the visibility of the most recent work. Decades ago, papers would be sent by postal mail to friends, other departments, and, in some cases, to paying subscribers.

This solution had a major drawback, though: Only the top institutions had ways to disseminate the frontier of research among their contacts, mostly other top institutions, while the rest of the economics profession was left to discover where the frontier of research was a few years ago in published journals. This system led to frustration for those left out.

The emergence of the Internet for broader academic use enabled significant change. In 1992, Thomas Krichel, then a graduate student at the University of Surrey, organized lists of working paper titles to be disseminated by email using the Coryfee mailing list. In 1993, the late Bob Parks, then an associate professor at Washington University in St. Louis, created EconWPA using an early arXiv codebase, which allowed the upload and download of working papers through email. When a linked file transfer protocol called Gopher was introduced, Thomas Krichel and José Manuel Barrueco Cruz, a librarian at the University of Valencia, made directories of papers available through that protocol in 1993. After the advent of the World Wide Web, the years of cumulated efforts moved to the Web in 1994 and Thomas Krichel created a series of websites under the NetEc umbrella that catalogued more and more economic research: EconWPA, BibEc, and WoPEc. Eventually, this stream of new papers online became too much to handle for a few volunteers to track by themselves. To ensure efforts were sustainable, Thomas Krichel developed a schema in 1997 to decentralize the cataloging. Thus, RePEc was born.

RePEc stands for **R**esearch **P**apers in **E**conomics. Its stated goal is to enhance the dissemination of economic research, both for authors and readers. Its basic principle is that all the necessary indexing of economic literature is decentralized. Each contributing publisher is responsible for maintaining an inventory of their publications. For RePEc, a publisher is any institution, from an academic press to a university economics department, a research center, a think tank, or a policy institution, such as a central bank or a government ministry. Most of these institutions have some sort of academic output, which is a major focus in RePEc: formal journal articles, books, and chapters or informal working papers or software components.

The decentralized model ensures that those who benefit the most from RePEc are also those who bear the cost of indexing, thus, the core team of RePEc volunteers, initially Thomas Krichel, and José Manuel Barrueco Cruz then joined by others, can concentrate on coordinating, monitoring, and providing user services. The cost to users can be kept at a minimum (zero beyond the labor for indexing by publishers) thanks to some sponsorship for hosting services.

The data that enter RePEc are available in a machine-readable format, but not in a way that is readily consumable by human users for easy discovery across publishers. Thus, the core team of volunteers created a set of websites to transform the data and make it more accessible. Initially, WoPEc and BibEc provided this access. Later, IDEAS and EconPapers made RePEc

data available for bibliographic discovery. Other, broader bibliographic tools later started indexing RePEc-aggregated metadata, including Google Scholar, OpenAIRE, Proquest, OpenAlex, Econlit, and more. (All mentioned websites are listed at the end of this chapter.)

Over time the scope of the data collected has expanded beyond traditional bibliographic items to more robust metadata describing the larger research information lifecycle, such as person and institution metadata. The bibliographic services themselves were also enhanced, adding features such as extracted references that are matched with items indexed in RePEc, thus supporting citation tracking, and disseminating new papers through various channels such as email lists.

In many ways, RePEc was an open research information pioneer, organized before other services emerged, such as ORCID, Research Organization Registry (ROR), CrossRef, and OpenCITE, which operate across all sciences and were preceded by corresponding RePEc services, services that are still active. While RePEc had all its projects natively linked with each other from the start, ORCID, ROR, and other services were all independently created and without interoperability designed natively. Some, such as ORCID and Google Scholar, even started by using seed data from RePEc.

2. A walk through RePEc metadata

RePEc provides both metadata and user services that also collect additional data that can be leveraged by the various RePEc services. This section walks through the different object types as a way to describe those RePEc services.

The foundation of all the data collected by RePEc is the metadata about publications provided by the participating publishers. The basic principle is that publishers host the data in a “RePEc archive” on their own server—permitted protocols include ftp, http, and https—at a web address that is known to RePEc. RePEc further disseminates this address, and the corpus of the metadata is thus available in a decentralized fashion to anyone who wants to use it. The core RePEc volunteers further add value by presenting the metadata corpus in a searchable way that is readily consumable by human users.

Each publisher’s RePEc archive can contain one or several “RePEc series,” of which there are five possible types of works: papers (working papers), articles (journal articles), books, chapters (book chapters), and software. Each of the series then contains items with metadata of the corresponding work type. At the time of this writing, there are over 2,400 RePEc archives.

The data are highly decentralized, which can make collecting and interpreting the raw data complicated for the end-user. While the data are in a format that can be easily read by a human and are machine readable because they have an easy structure and a limited set of elements, the format is unique and there is no widespread tool for machine ingest. Thus, a custom interface allows end-users to work with this data. An example data template for this chapter is below, with some fictitious information for the purpose of a more complete illustration. Note the use of handles for cross-linking of data. Other object types follow similar structures.

Template-Type ReDIF-Chapter 1.0

Title: RePEc, a Tool and Dataset for and about Economists

Author-Name: Anna Oates Schlaack

Author-Person: poa7

Author-Workplace-Name: University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign

Author-Name: Christian Zimmermann

Author-Person: pzi1

Author-Workplace-Name: Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis

Abstract: RePEc is an initiative created by economists for economists in 1997. [...]

Year: 2026

Month: September

File-URL: https://link.springer.com/rwe/10.1007/978-3-319-57365-6_412-1

DOI: 10.1007/978-3-319-57365-6_412-1

Classification-JEL: A11, A14, J44, J45

Book-Title: Handbook of Labor, Human Resources and Population Economics

In-Book: RePEc:spr:sprbok:978-3-319-57365-6

Handle: RePEc:spr:chp:978-3-319-57365-6_412-1

Two websites, EconPapers and IDEAS, allow the general user to interact with the data: browsing through various facets of the data or using an internal search engine. Other services like Google Scholar, OpenAlex, Econlit, etc. index RePEc data alongside other resources. In addition to EconPapers and IDEAS, RePEc offers two dissemination services for new material, NEP (via emails, RSS feed, and social media) and MyIDEAS (via a user account and emails).

While the publication data are useful for literature discovery, the real power of RePEc is realized in the data relationships between object types. Additional RePEc services collect or manage data, enabling meaningful connections between publication data or bibliographic resources, as well as other object types, such as persons and institutions. This relational data is particularly powerful in that the data are natively linked within RePEc through publicly available RePEc handles. RePEc services leverage these relationships, adding value to the core data, and end-users can easily identify linkages and create networks between object types when using the RePEc raw data.

Many readers should be familiar with the RePEc Author Service, which allows authors to create an online profile that lists their publications indexed in RePEc, along with their affiliation(s) and various other details about their online presence. An important aspect of this service is that the user must explicitly acknowledge and claim authorship of the items the RePEc Author Service identified based on author name matches. This author review resolves issues with attributions of works across homonyms or near homonyms (initialed names) that could fail with automatic attributions. Publishers may provide RePEc author handles in the item records, which will automatically match items to authors in the RePEc Author Service. The Author Service also links different versions of a work based on two criteria: title similarity and whether the different versions of a work are associated with an author's profile.

Another set of metadata stems from a service called EDIRC, or **E**conomics **D**epartments, **I**nstitutes and **R**esearch **C**enters in the World, which actually predates RePEc by two years. EDIRC is a directory of institutions that principally employ economists; its metadata is used

mainly as a controlled vocabulary for affiliations in the RePEc Author Service and to identify some publishers.

The RePEc Genealogy is an academic family tree that collects information about the education of registered authors, including year of graduation, institution, and advisor(s). It leverages metadata about institutions and persons from EDIRC and the RePEc Author Service, respectively. It is an open wiki, so any registered RePEc Author Service user can contribute to the collected data. For example, a user might add alumni from their graduate program.

There is also CitEc, a reference extraction and citation service. It attempts to extract references from any indexed item that has corresponding full text that CitEc can access. CitEc then attempts to match references with the existing items indexed in RePEc. Because commercial publishers have paywalls and do not make references openly available, many publishers supply the references separately; authors can also enter missing references in CitEc.

Finally, CollEc is a project that creates a co-authorship network across registered authors and defines various measures of network centrality and network betweenness for each author within that network.

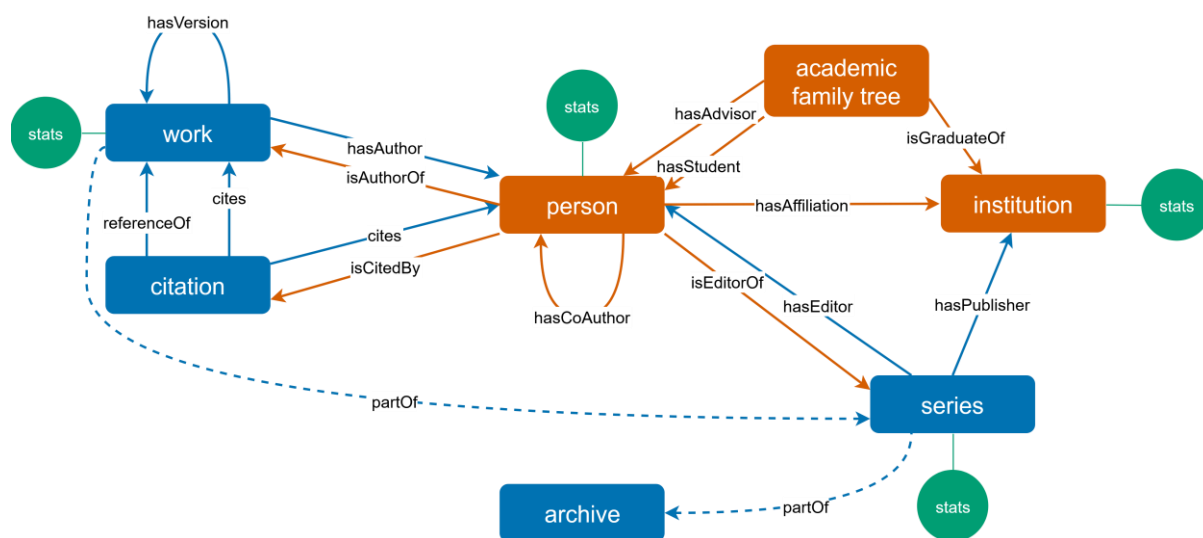


Figure 1: An illustration of the links between object types in RePEc

The universe of RePEc metadata is a mesh linking various object types: archives, series, works of different types, persons, and institutions. Even the links can be of various relationship types. For example, a link between a person and an institution can be through current affiliation or alma mater. A link between a work and an institution can exist because the institution published the work or because a person affiliated with the institution authored the work. Finally, links between works may exist because they are different versions, references, or citations.

In addition, all these collected data allow RePEc to create various metrics for evaluating RePEc series, authors, their institutions, and graduate programs. The evaluation service, RePEc Rankings, supplies many definitions of citation metrics, including various impact factors, the h-index, Euclidian citation scores, and others.

At the time of this writing, RePEc collects data from 2,400 archives (publishers), has indexed 5.5 million works, has 74,000 registered authors (including 27,000 with genealogy records), lists

15,000 institutions, has extracted 100 million references, and has 36 million citations matched to indexed works.

3. How to access RePEc data

RePEc data are publicly accessible on the various RePEc services with few exceptions due to privacy and general relevance considerations. Namely, email addresses are not currently made public and rankings beyond the top ones stay private. In principle, one can scrape the various RePEc websites to obtain the desired information. This is not advisable, though, for two reasons. First, web scraping does not guarantee completeness. IDEAS, for example, has over 6 million web pages, and a scraping script can easily get lost or overwhelmed. Second, web scraping can stress RePEc servers, especially with ill-configured scripts that run in loops across all the links. Therefore, the recommended approach to retrieve RePEc data is through Perl scripts provided by RePEc. The scripts allow users to mirror content from all ~2,400 publishers, as well as person and institution data. There are also portals that allow users to obtain all or part of the data through ftp, rsync, or OAI-PMH protocols. Finally, two APIs are available. One is dedicated to CitEc data, and the other spans all RePEc data and includes some massaging of raw data, such as enhanced paper version relationships, statistics, and particular subsets of data. APIs are not ideal for downloading the full corpus of data, though; they are designed to obtain many small snippets of data.

4. RePEc metadata as a source for labor economists

While RePEc is a bibliographic database, it has information that supports the study of economists within the profession more broadly. Indeed, each registered author has a publication history and a measure of the strength of that history as a performance metric. Often, the data include the economist's employer, the type and strength of that employer, where the economist studied and the strength of that institution. In addition, RePEc has inferred the person's gender from their full name with manual corrections for quality control. A major drawback of the RePEc data model is that RePEc does not support a complete affiliation history, only current affiliation(s) and graduated from institutions.

Despite some limitations, the highly relational data means that one can study the characteristics of professionals with high human capital and potentially high geographic mobility. The data can indicate gender, subfields in which economists work, how they perform over time across many metrics, and with whom they choose to work, including the characteristics of those collaborators. Events can be dated: graduation year if reported in RePEc Genealogy; always a year of first publication, which can function as a proxy for age; the publication history; and some dates of death.

While these data do not rise to the level of administrative data, as their collection is voluntary and relies on the goodwill of participants, it is quite a large and rich dataset for the scope of a highly specialized profession. For example, the 74,000 registered and published authors are a multiple of the 15,000 members of the American Economic Association, the largest professional society in economics. In many countries, the registered author count is high enough to obtain a statistically sufficient dataset. The same applies to many subfields of economics. Also, while other datasets that have been assembled to study economists focus on a few journals or authors

within a narrow set of institutions, the RePEc dataset expands the scope worldwide, including the Global South. Of particular interest is the dating of working papers, which allows to date more precisely when research was performed compared with a publication date in a journal, which may be several years after the research was conducted.

5. Examples of uses of RePEc metadata in labor economics

Over a hundred studies have been conducted using RePEc data, either in part or wholly (a link to a maintained list of studies is at the end of the chapter). This section presents a few studies that are most relevant to a labor economist and that highlight the usefulness of RePEc data. Other common uses fall into bibliometrics, including various ways to rank journals and economists; studying the dissemination of research; and patterns of citations, for example.

The ability to track economists' publishing performance is of prime interest to labor economists. This can be measured by the RePEc rankings of the economists or in more detail by tracking their publication year by year with the associated citation measures for the article or impact factors of the outlets.

One strand of studies tracks the careers of economists and looks at factors that can explain them. For example, Krapf et al. (2017) links a survey of economists to their RePEc author profiles and, thus, their publication timelines to tease out the impact of also being a parent of young children. They find that fatherhood has a positive impact on publication success and that mothers seem to outperform non-mothers after an initial penalty period, except for unmarried mothers and those having children before age 30.

One can also study career choices. An early choice is that of the dissertation advisor. García-Suaza et al. (2020) studies the impact of student-advisor matches and find that advisor choice matters little in top PhD programs unless they are co-authors. In other programs, the quality of the advisor matters much more. These results are obtained by leveraging RePEc profiles of authors in RePEc Genealogy, ranking data for authors and departments, as well as journal impact factors from RePEc.

Another early choice is whether one should diversify one's fields of research. Conventional wisdom is that one should concentrate on the field of the PhD field until tenure is obtained. Dellas et al. (2026) contradicts this by using measures of research field dispersion and publication success, both extracted from RePEc data. Early diversifiers show better scores throughout their careers, even when restricted to graduates from top programs (with information from the RePEc Genealogy).

More generally, one can ask what it takes to be a successful professional and apply it to economists. Using data from EDIRC, RePEc author profiles, and institutional and author h-indices, Rybacki and Serwa (2021) predict h-indices for central banks and central bankers. The conclusion is that central bankers are more successful if they work in well-connected, larger, Western central banks. Zacchia (2021) concentrates on women, using RePEc authors rankings and matching authors with their academic status. The conclusion is that women achieve less career promotion success compared to men after controlling for their ranking.

Another aspect of academic labor that can be studied with RePEc data is the impact of an economist and how they are valued: what is the contribution of an individual author to a research field? Hsieh et al. (2020) uses RePEc data to create a co-authorship network from

RePEc author profiles and run experiments by removing an author and looking at how the new network as whole produces research. This allows one to isolate how authors contribute to research by elevating others.

The economics profession is also a social construct where belonging to specific networks helps in one's career. Kleemans and Thornton (2021) looks at NBER membership using CVs for economists at R1 universities and RePEc and finds that publications in the top 5 journals matter more than an economist's total publications. Connections with current NBER members, either the advisor or colleagues, have significant impact on one's success. Tol (2022) studies the student-advisor network among economics Nobel Prize laureates using RePEc Genealogy (academic family tree) and other sources and finds the laureate network to be highly concentrated.

There are many more studies using RePEc data in one way or another, and future labor economists will surely find innovative ways to continue exploiting this data.

6. Conclusion

RePEc has been collecting information about economics publications and the economics profession for about 30 years. The data can be informative not just to understand the publication landscape, but also how a profession functions: What drives performance, how do people respond to incentives, who do they choose to work with, what work strategies do they adopt. Economists are highly educated, are usually very mobile, have high standards, and are passionate about their work. RePEc data allow one to analyse not only the economics profession with these characteristics, but also other professions with these characteristics.

RePEc has data about many facets of an economists work and work environment. The data are freely accessible and have already been used to answer some research questions. Labor economists are strongly encouraged to find more use for it and further contribute to their literature, which will duly be indexed in RePEc.

7. Mentioned, active websites and web pages

Works using RePEc data <https://ideas.repec.org/k/repecdt.html>

How to obtain RePEc data <https://ideas.repec.org/getdata.html>

arXiv <https://arxiv.org/>

CitEc <https://citec.repec.org/>

CollEc <https://collec.repec.org/>

CrossRef <https://www.crossref.org/>

Econlit <https://aeaweb.org/econlit/>

EconPapers <https://econpapers.repec.org/>

EconWPA <https://econwpa.ub.uni-muenchen.de/> (archived)

EDIRC <https://edirc.repec.org/>

Google Scholar <https://scholar.google.com/>

IDEAS <https://ideas.repec.org/>

MyIDEAS <https://ideas.repec.org/cgi-bin/myideas.cgi>
New Economics Papers (NEP) <https://nep.repec.org/>
OpenCITE <https://opencite.space/>
OpenAIRE <https://www.openaire.eu/>
OpenAlex <https://openalex.org/>
ORCID <https://orcid.org/>
Proquest <https://www.proquest.com/>
RePEc <http://repec.org/>
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RePEc Genealogy <https://genealogy.repec.org/>
Research Organization Registry (ROR) <https://ror.org/>

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